Seagate: qualified storage capacity and better earnings per exabyte

Seagate earns its place in the AI buildout through scarce, qualified storage capacity. More model activity, video and persistent context create data worth retaining. HAMR increases the bytes delivered by each drive, while manufacturing complexity and customer qualification limit how quickly competitors can provide equivalent accepted capacity.

The investment edge is the bridge from accepted exabytes and contract renewal to manufacturer profit after real costs. Rising storage density, a richer HAMR mix and selective price realization can lift earnings faster than revenue. The October pricing checks support a larger price endpoint inside a finite existing branch; they supply no additional Seagate shipments.

Current analytical output	Value	Interpretation
Q4 2027 ceiling	USD 1,327 per share	Q4 2027 through Q3 2028 adjusted operating profit
Q1 2028 ceiling	USD 1,407 per share	Q1 through Q4 2028 adjusted operating profit
Valuation method	20x / 231 million diluted shares	Current quarter plus next three; starting-quarter denominator
Analytical score	47 / 60; 78 / 100	Seven categories reassessed; High Conviction
Portfolio Excel Base	78 / 100	Separate existing owner control

Research date: October 21, 2026. The new broker preview is dated October 20 at 03:44 UTC, or October 19 late evening in Toronto. The latest actual quarter ended July 3. Its earnings event and supplemental information are dated July 28, while the original release PDF carries a Singapore July 29 dateline. The next results call is October 27 at 5 pm ET and has not occurred at this research cutoff. No unsupported explanation is imposed on the release-date difference. [HDD-P2; STX-REL; STX-SUP; STX-EVENT]

Financial tables use USD millions and whole-number display unless stated. Nonzero financial amounts below USD 1 million appear as <1; true zeros remain 0. Nonzero rates below 1% appear as <1%. Shares are millions, physical capacity is exabytes (EB), and storage prices are USD per terabyte (TB). Small price premiums and concessions use whole US cents per TB. Rounding may prevent displayed totals from adding exactly; exact calculations remain in the model and technical supplement.

Historical snapshot: USD 877 per share at the September 21, 2026 close and approximately 227 million basic shares in the dated filing snapshot. The exact historical observations are preserved in the supplement. They do not determine the forward share count, score or ceiling, and no fresh quote is implied. [STX-10K; STX-QUOTE]

Business, bottleneck and competitive alternatives

Seagate supplies hard-disk drives and associated storage systems for cloud, enterprise and edge uses. The model separates HAMR data-center HDDs, other data-center HDDs and Edge/IoT. The producer sells accepted physical capacity; storage demanded by an application becomes revenue only when the right drives can be built, qualified, delivered and recognized.

HAMR uses localized heating to write smaller magnetic grains. Precision heads, media, integrated recording lasers, firmware, manufacturing yields and field reliability form the platform. Mozaic gives Seagate an operating lead, but each generation adds process complexity and must qualify with customers. More bytes per disk can support more exabytes while finished-drive units remain relatively stable. [STX-10K; Q4-CALL]

Western Digital and Toshiba remain viable large-scale HDD suppliers. Their density progress and accepted supply constrain the duration of scarcity rents. SSDs compete where latency, power, footprint or falling NAND cost outweigh HDD capacity economics. A small company cannot readily recreate a qualified nearline recording platform; no filing-supported microcap direct substitute was identified. Seagate recording lasers do not establish a separate merchant laser opportunity for an unrelated photonics supplier.

Opportunity phase	How Seagate can capture it	Economic boundary
2026-27: commercial ramp	Higher-density qualified HDDs, renewals and limited extra accepted output	HAMR replaces older Seagate data-center capacity inside the same shipped-EB total
2028-29: data retention	Persistent context, video and enterprise/cloud data lakes	Existing demand index; constrained by manufacturing and customer intake
2030 and later: physical AI	Sensor/video history and repeated training data may expand retention	LOW-confidence intensity proxy; no separate robotics or KV-cache revenue

HBM, DRAM, SSDs and HDDs serve different parts of the data hierarchy. Persistent low-cost capacity can benefit after a GPU is installed, but no assumption requires every token or video stream to be retained forever. Management describes KV-cache and physical-AI opportunities as early and application-dependent. Neither newest call supplies a universal HDD-per-GPU, per-rack or per-watt coefficient. [Q3-CALL; Q4-CALL]

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Latest actuals and the first modeled quarter

Fiscal Q4 2026 ended July 3 and maps to the calendar Q2 bucket. The first forecast bucket, Q3 2026, maps to fiscal Q1 2027. The mapping repeats around a June fiscal year-end; the July 3 result is not an extra third-quarter actual. [STX-REL; STX-SUP]

Reported period / basis	Revenue	Gross profit	Opex excluding COGS	Operating profit
FY2026 Q3; April 3 end; GAAP	3,112	1,447	449	998

Reported period / basis	Revenue	Gross profit	Opex excluding COGS	Operating profit
FY2026 Q3; adjusted	3,112	1,463	296	1,167
FY2026 Q4; July 3 end; GAAP	3,629	1,898	339	1,559
FY2026 Q4; adjusted	3,629	1,912	293	1,619
Full FY2026; GAAP	12,195	-	-	4,094
Full FY2026; adjusted	12,195	-	-	4,450

The July guide calls for USD 4,000-4,200 million revenue, approximately USD 300 million adjusted operating expense and approximately 50% adjusted operating margin. Midpoint arithmetic gives about USD 2,050 million operating profit and USD 2,350 million gross profit. That implied gross margin is an approximate calculation, rather than a separately issued exact margin guide. The EPS midpoint and range are retained at source precision only in the technical supplement. [STX-SUP; Q4-CALL]

The first model quarter matches USD 4,100 million sales, USD 2,350 million gross profit, USD 300 million opex and USD 2,050 million adjusted operating profit. The USD 3,375 million data-center / USD 725 million Edge split and 215 EB are analytical allocations, not issuer segment guidance. Product margins calibrate to the consolidated guide. They do not become separately observed product profitability.

Guidance Q1FY27

Q1FY27	
Revenue	$4.1 billion ± $100 million
Operating Margin[1] (non-GAAP)	Approximately 50% of revenue
Diluted Earnings Per Share[1,2] (non-GAAP)	$7.30 ± $0.20

At the mid point of the guidance[3]:

- Operating Expense (non-GAAP) expected to be ~$300 million
- Tax Expense (non-GAAP) expected to be ~16% of income before taxes
- Diluted Shares O/S for EPS (non-GAAP) expected to be ~231 million including estimated dilution from Exchangeable Senior Notes due 2028[4] of ~2 million shares

1. We have not reconciled our non-GAAP diluted EPS guidance for fiscal first quarter 2027 to the most directly comparable GAAP measure, other than estimated share-based compensation expenses, because material items that may impact these measures are out of our control and/or cannot be reasonably predicted, including, but not limited to, net (gain) loss from debt transactions, strategic investment losses (gains) or impairment charges, income tax adjustments on these measures, and other charges or benefits that may arise. The amounts of these measures are not currently available but may be material to future results. A reconciliation of our historical non-GAAP financial measures to their nearest GAAP equivalent is contained in this release.
2. Guidance regarding non-GAAP diluted earnings per share excludes known pre-tax charges related to estimated share-based compensation expenses of $0.26 per share.
3. Guidance based on announced tariff policies as of July 28th, 2026, and reflects minimal direct impact to Q1FY27 financial outlook.
4. Refer to Illustrative Table of Potential Dilutive Impact of Exchangeable Senior Notes due 2028

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STX-SUP, original page 7: July 28 fiscal Q1 FY2027 outlook. Original source decimals and wording remain unchanged. EPS guidance is a cross-check, not the operating-profit valuation input.

Adjusted accounting, ordinary depreciation and stock compensation

The selected valuation basis is adjusted operating profit. In the latest actual quarter, GAAP gross profit of USD 1,898 million increases by USD 14 million to USD 1,912 million, and USD 339 million operating expense declines by USD 46 million to USD 293 million. Together these changes increase operating profit by USD 60 million, from USD 1,559 million to USD 1,619 million. [STX-REL; STX-SUP]

GAAP-to-adjusted item	Gross-profit add-back	Opex excluded	OP increase
Ordinary stock compensation	13	41	54
Acquired intangible amortization	1	0	1
Restructuring	0	4	4
Other adjustment	0	1	1
Total	14	46	60

Stock compensation remains a real shareholder cost under this adjusted convention. A flat diluted share path does not itself pay for future awards or their cash replacement. The model retains its existing adjusted basis and makes no second earnings add-back. Ordinary production depreciation remains in cost; quarter depreciation and amortization totaled USD 70 million. Operating profit therefore differs from EBITDA. [STX-REL; STX-SUP]

The release table labels USD 2,070 million as total operating expenses including USD 1,731 million cost of revenue. The separate USD 339 million opex excludes production cost and matches the reconciliation. Subtracting both USD 2,070 million and USD 1,731 million would double-count manufacturing cost.

Reconciliation of GAAP Gross Profit to Non-GAAP Gross Profit ($M)	Q4FY25	Q1FY26	Q2FY26	Q3FY26	Q4FY26	FY26
GAAP Gross Profit	**$ 914**	**$ 1,037**	**$ 1,176**	**$ 1,447**	**$ 1,898**	**$ 5,558**
Amortization of acquired intangible assets	—	3	2	2	1	8
Purchase order cancellation fees	(5)	—	—	—	—	—
Restructuring and other, net	3	—	—	—	—	—
Share-based compensation	14	14	13	14	13	54
Non-GAAP Gross Profit	**$ 926**	**$ 1,054**	**$ 1,191**	**$ 1,463**	**$ 1,912**	**$ 5,620**
GAAP Gross Margin %	37.4%	39.4%	41.6%	46.5%	52.3%	45.6%
Non-GAAP Gross Margin %	37.9%	40.1%	42.2%	47.0%	52.7%	46.1%

Reconciliation of GAAP Operating Expenses to Non-GAAP Operating Expenses ($M)	Q4FY25	Q1FY26	Q2FY26	Q3FY26	Q4FY26	FY26
GAAP Operating Expenses	**$ 346**	**$ 343**	**$ 333**	**$ 449**	**$ 339**	**$ 1,464**
Acquisition-related charges	(2)	(1)	—	—	—	(1)
Legal settlement	—	—	—	(105)	—	(105)
Restructuring and other, net	(13)	(13)	(3)	(7)	(4)	(27)
Share-based compensation	(45)	(38)	(40)	(40)	(41)	(159)
Other charges	—	—	—	(1)	(1)	(2)
Non-GAAP Operating Expenses	**$ 286**	**$ 291**	**$ 290**	**$ 296**	**$ 293**	**$ 1,170**

Reconciliation of GAAP Income From Operations to Non-GAAP Income From Operations ($M)	Q4FY25	Q1FY26	Q2FY26	Q3FY26	Q4FY26	FY26
GAAP Income From Operations	**$ 568**	**$ 694**	**$ 843**	**$ 998**	**$ 1,559**	**$ 4,094**
Acquisition-related charges	2	1	—	—	—	1
Amortization of acquired intangible assets	—	3	2	2	1	8
Legal settlement	—	—	—	105	—	105
Purchase order cancellation fees	(5)	—	—	—	—	—
Restructuring and other, net	16	13	3	7	4	27
Share-based compensation	59	52	53	54	54	213
Other charges	—	—	—	1	1	2
Non-GAAP Income From Operations	**$ 640**	**$ 763**	**$ 901**	**$ 1,167**	**$ 1,619**	**$ 4,450**
GAAP Operating Margin %	23.2 %	26.4 %	29.8 %	32.1 %	43.0 %	33.6 %
Non-GAAP Operating Margin %	26.2 %	29.0 %	31.9 %	37.5 %	44.6 %	36.5 %

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STX-SUP, original page 11. GAAP and adjusted gross profit, operating expense and operating income are reconciled by the issuer. Ordinary stock compensation is among the excluded costs; source decimals remain intact.

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Reported product rounding and the calibrated starting point

The supplement shows rounded data-center sales of USD 2,933 million and Edge/IoT of USD 697 million, totaling USD 3,630 million against consolidated sales of USD 3,629 million. The retained calibration uses USD 2,932 million data-center sales, calculated as consolidated revenue less Edge. This USD 1 million presentation residual is not a new sales input. [STX-SUP]

Seagate reported 195 nearline EB and 218 total HDD EB; the remaining 23 EB are non-nearline. Data-center revenue includes cloud, enterprise, VIA and systems. The retained USD 2,932 million divided by 195 EB is an effective calibration, rather than an exactly disclosed pure-drive net price.

A 40% HAMR nearline exit-run-rate mix and a 4% relative price premium produce a useful illustrative actual-quarter allocation. That mix need not equal the entire quarter average. The inherited HAMR/other product revenue and margin split is analytical and LOW confidence; only the consolidated actual and guide are source anchors. No new source reveals a replacement bill of materials, yield curve or fixed/variable manufacturing schedule.

Quantity or scope	Latest disclosed / retained	Boundary
Reported data-center / Edge revenue	USD 2,933 million / USD 697 million	Rounded source categories

Quantity or scope	Latest disclosed / retained	Boundary
Retained calibration data-center revenue	USD 2,932 million	Consolidated revenue less Edge
Nearline / total capacity	195 EB / 218 EB	Physical measures, distinct from revenue mix
Reported HAMR nearline exit mix	40%	Run rate, not exact quarter-average product revenue
Model guide split	USD 3,375 million / USD 725 million	Data-center / Edge analytical allocation

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What changed in the October pricing evidence

Morgan Stanley's October 20 preview describes non-contracted nearline transactions at USD 40-70 per TB, compared with roughly USD 15 blended. It also describes non-nearline sequential price increases of 15-30% or more and constrained media/equipment supply. The industry shortage estimate of about 400 EB in 2027/28 repeats the earlier mechanism. It is unmet demand, not accepted Seagate output. [HDD-P2, pages 2-3]

The bank's 10-30% floating-sales example is hypothetical. Transaction quantities, customer/product mix, channel fees, geographic coverage and manufacturer net realization remain unavailable. The bank's qualitative description of Seagate as more aggressive than WDC supports direction without specifying a larger numerical exposure. Its target price, fiscal P/E and model matrices supply no operating-model inputs.

The selected endpoint is USD 40, the low end of the newer observed range. It replaces USD 30 within the same finite branch. Probability remains 30%, with eligibility limited to 10% of already qualified shipped EB. The observation comes from the same broker/source group and does not demonstrate broader producer capture. Those reasons support a larger conditional endpoint without raising probability or eligible share.

are 10%+ above Street EPS forecasts in the December quarter (and think we could still be conservative in areas).

At the same time, we acknowledge the HDD catalyst path is cloudier today vs. a month ago – the market faces uncertainty on vendor rationality and sources of AI funding that won't be solved with earnings, and we have reduced our target multiples as a result. **But at ~8x P/E, current valuation implies HDD earnings peak in FY28 and that SSD pricing declines 80% over the next 2-3 years, severely limiting HDD pricing upside (more below).** Plausible? Sure. But (1) is that overly punitive given what we know about HDD, and broader AI, demand, and (2) does that create a positive asymmetrical setup where we can buy on oversold discounts? Yes, absolutely, in our view. As a result, we reiterate our Overweight rating on both STX ($1,200 PT; 82% upside) and WDC ($643 PT; 83% upside) and reinstate STX as our 'Top Pick' in IT Hardware.

First, let's get into the details of our recent checks – Toshiba, demand, pricing, etc. On Toshiba, our checks suggest there is little new HDD supply/demand risk – Toshiba remains gated by parts of the HDD supply chain (media, equipment), they are effectively already sold out of capacity for CY27, and recent expectations for a ~400EB HDD industry supply shortfall in CY27/CY28 (vs. 300EBs in CY26) are consistent with our checks a month ago. Also, the more work we do on Toshiba, the more it sounds like they are *more* aggressive on pricing than STX/WDC. Said differently, we remain comfortable with the Toshiba risk, despite the evolving headlines. On HDD demand and pricing – our checks make clear that EB demand has accelerated in recent months (recent cloud checks would support this), and that the customer base is broadening from core CSPs to new AI-centric customers (e.g. frontier labs) trying to buy HDD capacity in size (i.e. 100's of EBs). Supply shortages are limiting their ability to procure in size, but desperation for storage capacity is also pushing spot nearline HDD prices higher – we continue to hear about recent non-contracted deals getting closed at 4c/GB up to 7c/GB (vs. blended nearline pricing at ~1.5c/GB today). Finally, non-nearline HDD pricing remains extremely strong – and as NAND prices continue their march higher, the HDD industry is persistently raising non-nearline prices 15-30%+ Q/Q to capture better margins. It is our understanding all of these trends are consistent for both STX and WDC, although STX appears to be a bit more aggressive in capturing floating (e.g. spot) prices than WDC.

What does this mean for the STX/WDC earnings setup? A September quarter beat and a better-than expected pricing and profitability-driven raise in the December quarter. Somewhat controversially, we think this quarter's earnings setup is more attractive for WDC. Based on our investor conversations over the past month, we sense that investors are a bit less aggressive in modeling STX/WDC fundamentals, reflecting tempered enthusiasm following share underperformance over the past 90 days and recent Toshiba headlines (see here, here, and here). When juxtaposed versus the strength in our checks above, we believe the earnings setup for both WDC (Oct 22nd) and STX (Oct 27th) is attractive. And given the lower buyside bar at WDC, we think the F1Q earnings setup could be better for WDC over STX.

- **For STX:** For the September quarter, we forecast revenue of $4.16B (vs.

HDD-P2, original page 2. Morgan Stanley Research, October 20, 2026 at 03:44 UTC. Private licensed source exhibit. Price checks, unmet industry demand and broker forecasts have different scopes; source targets and probabilities are not imported.

Contracts determine how much of a spot premium reaches Seagate

$4.00B-$4.20B guide) and a gross margin of 57.9%, leading to $7.50 of EPS vs. Street at $7.41. However, if recent history is a guide, results could come in closer to $4.26B of revenue and $8.13 of EPS. Looking to the December qtr, we model 6% Q/Q EB growth, MSD-HSD% Q/Q nearline pricing growth, higher-capacity mix and continued cost downs to drive $4.76B of revenue, a 62.1% gross margin, and EPS of $9.54, 6-12% above Consensus (Exhibit 1). However, these forecasts assume sequential pricing growth for nearline and non-nearline EBs decelerates from the September quarter, which would run counter to our checks. If we were to assume 10-30% of nearline bits are floating and subject to spot prices while 70-90% gets repriced at LSD-MSD% Q/Q rates in the Dec Q, that could deliver HSD%+ Q/Q nearline $/TB growth vs. our ~7% Q/Q forecast, with non-nearline pricing strength representing further upside to our estimates. Ultimately, this means our above-Street December quarter EPS forecast could still be 5%+ too low.

- **For WDC:** For September, we forecast revenue of $4.19B (vs. $4.00B-$4.20B guidance) and a gross margin of 56.0% (vs. 55-56% guidance), leading to $4.13 of EPS vs. Street at $4.09. The key swing factor in the Sept Q is nearline EB execution following last quarter's underperformance, particularly whether WDC delivers on the "pretty steep ramp" of 40TB ePMR expected in C2H26. Looking to December qtr, we model 8% Q/Q EB growth, MSD% Q/Q nearline pricing growth and improving higher-capacity mix to support revenue of $4.79B, a 59.5% gross margin, and EPS of $5.25, 5-10% above Consensus (Exhibit 2). Though using the same pricing analysis as we did for STX above, December qtr EPS could land 8% above our forecast, or closer to $5.67. For context, our investor conversations point to December quarter buyside expectations of $4.75B-$4.95B revenue, a 59.5%-61.0% gross margin, and $5.20-$5.60 of EPS. However, it is well-understood WDC guides relatively conservatively, and thus a guide at the low-to-middle-end of buyside estimates is expected.

Exhibit 1: STX: Our September quarter EPS estimate is at the high end of mgmt's guide and largely in line with Consensus, but our December quarter EPS estimate is 12% above Street, driven by stronger pricing and higher margin assumptions.

STX	Sep-26					Dec-26				
($M)	MSe New	MSe Old	Diff.	Cons	Diff.	MSe New	MSe Old	Diff.	Cons	Diff.
Revenue	4,163	4,168	0%	4,135	1%	4,755	4,740	0%	4,515	5%
Total HDD EB	229	229	0%	237	-3%	243	249	-2%	249	-3%
Nearline EB	207	207	0%	213	-3%	219	225	-3%	222	-2%
Total Price per EB	$18.2	$18.2	0%	$17.5	4%	$19.6	$19.1	3%	$18.1	8%
Total Cost per EB	$7.7	$7.7	0%	$7.5	2%	$7.4	$7.3	1%	$7.5	0%
Gross Profit	2,412	2,410	0%	2,360	2%	2,954	2,915	1%	2,666	11%
Operating Profits	2,108	2,108	0%	2,069	2%	2,650	2,612	1%	2,368	12%
Profit Before Tax	2,060	2,061	0%	2,013	2%	2,622	2,584	1%	2,320	13%
Net Income	1,731	1,731	0%	1,706	1%	2,202	2,171	1%	1,968	12%
EPS	**$7.50**	**$7.50**	**0%**	**$7.41**	**1%**	**$9.54**	**$9.39**	**2%**	**$8.54**	**12%**
Gross Margin	57.9%	57.8%	10bps	57.1%	90bps	62.1%	61.5%	60bps	58.8%	330bps
Operating Margin	50.6%	50.6%	10bps	50.0%	60bps	55.7%	55.1%	60bps	52.4%	330bps
Diluted Shares (M)	231	231	0%	230	0%	231	231	0%	230	0%

Source: Company data, FactSet, Morgan Stanley Research estimates

HDD-P2, original page 3. The floating-share illustration is hypothetical; forward earnings and targets are bank forecasts. Source exhibits are preserved privately, with original numbers unchanged.

The July call describes roughly annual configuration and pricing visibility, staggered customer renegotiations and additional output made available two to three quarters ahead through yield or scrap improvements. That extra output can earn better prices than older commitments. Management did not disclose a floating

percentage or authorize repricing every contracted exabyte. Calendar 2027 commitments are material counter-evidence to broad immediate spot transmission. [Q4-CALL]

Preferential initial HAMR customer pricing was already a minimal June cohort and absent in September according to the July discussion. Its expiry helped only a little and did not explain the entire guide uplift. Renewal, product mix, incremental accepted output and like-for-like pricing must therefore remain separate mechanisms.

No named SpaceX order, accepted storage allocation or new company capacity is present in these checks. A broad compute spending plan does not provide Seagate-specific prices, wallet share, physical capacity or acceptance timing. The existing cloud/AI demand forecast already captures strong growth; no second spending multiplier is added.

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Nearline probability, timing, overlap and paid costs

Ledger item	Selected treatment	Evidence and limit
Economic probability	30%	Credible attributed transactions; unknown manufacturer capture and protected commitments
Eligible accepted capacity	10% of qualified shipped EB	Analytical bound; hypothetical floating share is not a measured sales mix
Conditional endpoint	USD 40 per TB	New low observed endpoint replaces the old USD 30 branch
Recognition phase	0 / 25 / 50 / 75 / 100%	Q3 2026 through Q3 2027; full through 2028
Fade	75 / 50 / 25 / 0% across 2029	Finite renewals/urgency; zero thereafter
Overlap	Subtract the full reference price; replace old branch once	No new volume, market-share, TAM or final-target probability addition
Manufacturing / fulfillment reserve	10% of incremental price revenue	Components, warranty/support and fulfillment; LOW proxy
Added operating support	3% of incremental price revenue	Ordinary manufacturing, R&D and SG&A remain paid
Net marginal adjusted OP	87% of new price revenue	Distinct from total product or company margin

Total revised price revenue equals qualified shipped EB x 30% probability x 10% eligible share x phase x the positive difference between USD 40 and the reference price. EB times USD/TB yields USD millions. This total branch includes contribution already present before the revision. Only the difference against the old USD 30 branch is fresh incremental revenue.

The full conditional price never becomes the company blended selling price. Fixed accepted output requires no additional drive-production project solely for the price residual, while the ordinary density ramp still needs

tooling, engineering and capital spending. The 10% cost and 3% support rates are explicit LOW-confidence allowances; neither newest call supplies a measured marginal-cost schedule.

Quarter	Phase	Shipped EB	Premium US cents/TB	Total branch R	COGS	Opex	Total branch OP
Q3 2026	0%	215	0	0	0	0	0
Q4 2026	25%	230	18	41	4	1	36
Q1 2027	50%	244	35	85	9	3	74
Q2 2027	75%	258	52	134	13	4	116
Q3 2027	100%	270	68	184	18	6	160
Q4 2027	100%	285	68	192	19	6	167
Q1 2028	100%	303	68	205	20	6	178
Q2 2028	100%	321	68	217	22	7	189
Q3 2028	100%	336	68	227	23	7	197
Q4 2028	100%	356	68	240	24	7	209
Q1 2029	75%	370	51	188	19	6	163
Q2 2029	50%	385	34	130	13	4	113
Q3 2029	25%	405	17	69	7	2	60
Q4 2029	0%	426	0	0	0	0	0
Q1 2030	0%	450	0	0	0	0	0
Q2 2030	0%	470	0	0	0	0	0
Q3 2030	0%	495	0	0	0	0	0
Q4 2030	0%	520	0	0	0	0	0

Premiums are shown in whole US cents per TB; 100 cents equals USD 1. The table is the TOTAL current scarcity branch above reference pricing. The dedicated revision bridge later isolates the change against the earlier model.

A finite Edge and IoT price residual

A non-nearline price check cannot be applied uniformly to Seagate's broader Edge/IoT category. The model uses the existing USD 725 million first-quarter allocation at a fixed quantity index, with one 15% conditional reprice. Conditional sales are approximately USD 834 million. The USD 725 million anchor and 25% eligible cohort are LOW analytical proxies; neither is issuer category guidance.

For Q4 2026, Q1 2027 and Q2 2027 only, the model subtracts the ENTIRE existing Edge revenue before retaining a positive residual. That removes ordinary growth and repricing already forecast. Probability is 30% and eligible share 25%. Incremental COGS of 15% plus operating support of 3% leave 82% of the bounded residual in adjusted operating profit.

Quarter	Conditional R	Existing R removed	Positive residual	Weighted new R	New COGS	New opex	New OP
Q4 2026	834	760	74	6	<1	<1	5
Q1 2027	834	745	89	7	<1	<1	5
Q2 2027	834	765	69	5	<1	<1	4

Across the three eligible quarters, the residual adds about USD 17 million sales and USD 14 million adjusted operating profit. It expires before the Q4 2027 forward-four-quarter valuation window, so it contributes zero to that active ceiling. The first guided quarter is unchanged and the 15% increase is not compounded each quarter.

The 90% and 110% quantity-index diagnostics test unknown mix/quantity inside the same conditional revenue pool. They add no units to the active company forecast. A lower quantity explanation removes some or all of the price residual after existing revenue is subtracted; a higher one leaves a larger residual.

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Physical demand and accepted capacity

The inherited demand index uses Amazon, Microsoft, Alphabet and Meta as a representative spending basket. Their preserved 2026 inputs total USD 732,500 million. Definitions differ across cash spending and finance leases, so this basket is a demand proxy rather than an HDD sales pool or a claim that each company is a disclosed Seagate customer. It embeds other cloud and enterprise business through calibration. [D1-D4]

Existing 2026 demand input	USD million	Boundary
Amazon	220,000	Cash capital-spending outlook; memory inflation is not extra physical capacity
Microsoft	175,000	Classification changed; physical investment expectations unchanged
Alphabet	200,000	Midpoint of USD 195,000-205,000 million
Meta	137,500	Midpoint including finance-lease principal

Existing 2026 demand input	USD million	Boundary
Total	732,500	Representative index; no second revenue multiplication

USD 2,932 million calibrated data-center sales divided by one quarter of the annual basket yields an effective coefficient near 2%. Exact precision is retained in the supplement. Matching one reported point establishes arithmetic consistency, not forecast accuracy or a disclosed supplier wallet share.

Annual basket growth assumptions are 25%, 20%, 14% and 10% for 2027-30. Retained-data intensity rises from 115% and 120% in the two 2026 forecast quarters to 125% in 2027/28, 130% in 2029 and 145% in 2030. Demand EB equals the 195 EB anchor times the spending index and intensity. Accepted output is capped by capacity and the existing qualification/allocation assumptions.

Physical demand, capacity and qualified shipments

Exabytes; all forecast quantities are analytical



Capacity and accepted output are LOW analytical paths beyond the guide anchor. Density supports more bytes with broadly stable drive units. No additional shipments are created by the 400 EB industry shortfall.

Quarter	Demand EB	Capacity EB	Qualified shipped EB
Q3 2026	224	215	215
Q4 2026	234	230	230
Q1 2027	305	244	244
Q2 2027	305	258	258
Q3 2027	305	270	270
Q4 2027	305	285	285
Q1 2028	366	303	303

Quarter	Demand EB	Capacity EB	Qualified shipped EB
Q2 2028	366	321	321
Q3 2028	366	336	336
Q4 2028	366	356	356
Q1 2029	433	370	370
Q2 2029	433	385	385
Q3 2029	433	405	405
Q4 2029	433	426	426
Q1 2030	532	450	450
Q2 2030	532	470	470
Q3 2030	532	495	495
Q4 2030	532	520	520

The retained path grows from 215 EB in Q3 2026 to 285 EB in Q4 2027 and 520 EB in Q4 2030. The model is already supply constrained. Additional factory names, platter area, component content, nominal industry capacity and accepted exabytes describe overlapping physical mechanisms and cannot be added as independent sales shocks.

Density, qualification and product substitution

July management reported a 40% HAMR nearline exit mix. The calendar-year-end HAMR crossover is distinct from Mozaic 4 reaching 50% of HAMR exabytes. The latter has a smaller denominator. Mozaic 4 was ramping at two large cloud customers; Mozaic 5 qualification shipments targeted late 2027 precede any accepted volume sales. [Q4-CALL]

Management describes additional heads/media content, longer process cycles, repeated tool visits, yield/scrap work and customer qualification. These consume resources even with flat finished-drive units. The July discussion mentioned 15-20% component-content growth in the prior year; that is not 15-20% finished-drive volume growth. The model pays ordinary production cost and retains the established ramp rather than inventing free capacity.

Quarter	HAMR mix	HAMR conversion	Shipped EB	HAMR EB	Other DC EB
Q3 2026	45%	100%	215	97	118
Q4 2026	50%	100%	230	115	115
Q1 2027	60%	100%	244	146	98
Q2 2027	70%	100%	258	181	77

Quarter	HAMR mix	HAMR conversion	Shipped EB	HAMR EB	Other DC EB
Q3 2027	75%	100%	270	203	68
Q4 2027	80%	100%	285	228	57
Q1 2028	82%	100%	303	248	55
Q2 2028	85%	100%	321	273	48
Q3 2028	88%	100%	336	296	40
Q4 2028	90%	100%	356	320	36
Q1 2029	91%	100%	370	337	33
Q2 2029	92%	100%	385	354	31
Q3 2029	93%	100%	405	377	28
Q4 2029	94%	100%	426	400	26
Q1 2030	95%	100%	450	428	23
Q2 2030	96%	100%	470	449	21
Q3 2030	96%	100%	495	475	20
Q4 2030	97%	100%	520	502	18

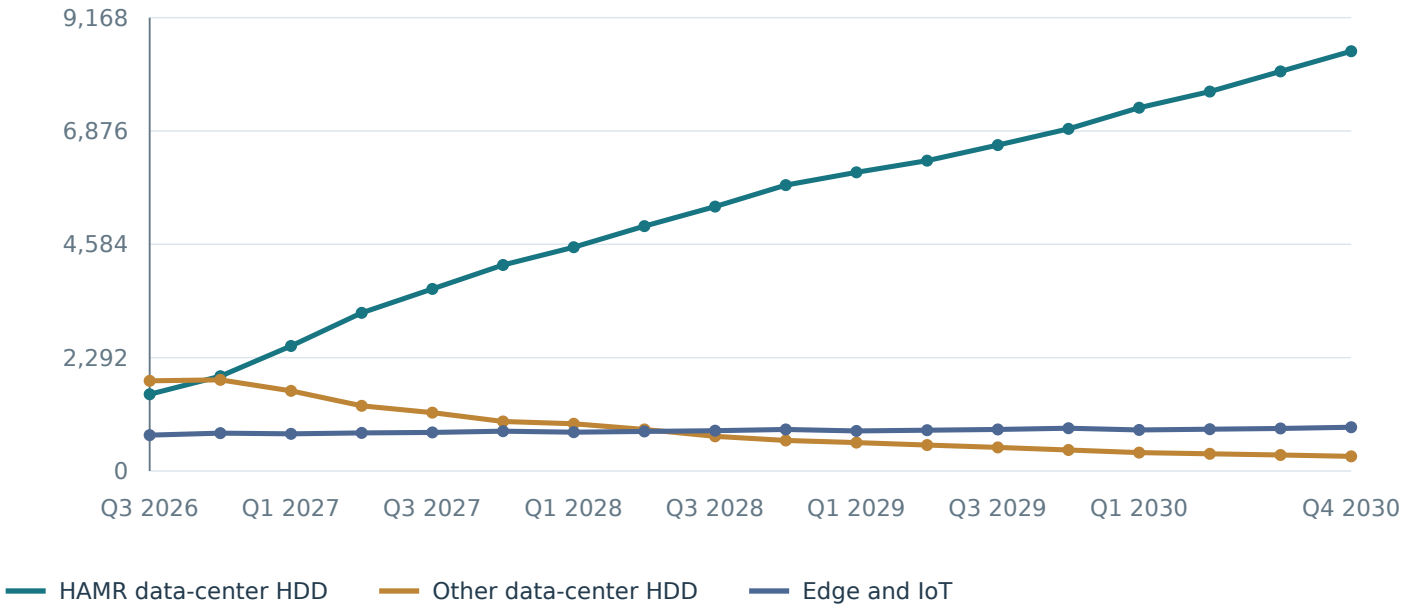
The selected conversion factor is 100% for the retained HAMR plan; it is an analytical assumption and does not remove actual acceptance risk. HAMR replaces the other data-center vector. A 4% relative HAMR price factor is normalized to the selected blended data-center price, so it supplies no second uplift to already blended revenue. Later mix and margins remain LOW confidence.

The September 10 conference reproduction informed the inherited 80-90% mix direction over roughly two years. A full primary conference transcript was unavailable and official audio was not compared. That reproduction is not upgraded to a newly verified primary source. The newest two completed earnings transcripts provide the primary commercial and manufacturing context. [STX-GS; Q3-CALL; Q4-CALL]

Product revenue and manufacturing architecture

Model revenue by product pool

USD millions; forecast product allocations



HAMR and other data-center products divide the same qualified output. Edge/IoT is a separate category; its short residual expires in Q2 2027. All product margins are analytical allocations, not reported segment guidance.

Quarter	HAMR data-center HDD	Other data-center HDD	Edge and IoT
Q3 2026	1,552	1,823	725
Q4 2026	1,917	1,843	766
Q1 2027	2,528	1,621	752
Q2 2027	3,198	1,318	770
Q3 2027	3,682	1,180	780
Q4 2027	4,166	1,001	805
Q1 2028	4,525	955	785
Q2 2028	4,952	840	800
Q3 2028	5,347	701	815
Q4 2028	5,781	618	840
Q1 2029	6,040	574	810

Quarter	HAMR data-center HDD	Other data-center HDD	Edge and IoT
Q2 2029	6,276	525	825
Q3 2029	6,591	477	840
Q4 2029	6,919	425	865
Q1 2030	7,346	372	830
Q2 2030	7,673	348	845
Q3 2030	8,081	324	860
Q4 2030	8,489	296	885

Each following table separates retained ordinary manufacturing cost from the incremental pricing-cost allowance. Ordinary production depreciation stays in the retained cost curve. The engine has no independently observed machinery commissioning cohorts, fixed/variable factory split, utilization or warranty schedule; those gaps must remain visible instead of being filled with invented precision.

Later HAMR gross margin approaches 70%, other data-center margin approximately 55% and Edge approximately 43% on the retained ordinary curves. These demanding outcomes require successful density, yield, reliability and customer value-sharing. Incremental price rent can lift total product margins above those reference curves. Management declined to guide a future total-company gross-margin target; an analyst's hypothetical 80% total margin is not company guidance. [Q4-CALL]

HAMR data-center HDD - all eighteen quarters

Quarter	Revenue	Ordinary COGS	Pricing COGS	Total COGS	Gross profit	Gross margin
Q3 2026	1,552	543	0	543	1,009	65%
Q4 2026	1,917	645	2	647	1,270	66%
Q1 2027	2,528	817	5	822	1,706	67%
Q2 2027	3,198	1,009	9	1,018	2,180	68%
Q3 2027	3,682	1,134	14	1,148	2,534	69%
Q4 2027	4,166	1,246	16	1,262	2,904	70%
Q1 2028	4,525	1,349	17	1,365	3,160	70%
Q2 2028	4,952	1,465	19	1,483	3,468	70%
Q3 2028	5,347	1,570	20	1,590	3,757	70%
Q4 2028	5,781	1,686	22	1,708	4,073	70%
Q1 2029	6,040	1,769	17	1,786	4,253	70%
Q2 2029	6,276	1,856	12	1,868	4,408	70%
Q3 2029	6,591	1,968	6	1,974	4,617	70%
Q4 2029	6,919	2,086	0	2,086	4,833	70%
Q1 2030	7,346	2,215	0	2,215	5,131	70%
Q2 2030	7,673	2,313	0	2,313	5,359	70%
Q3 2030	8,081	2,436	0	2,436	5,644	70%
Q4 2030	8,489	2,559	0	2,559	5,929	70%

USD millions. Ordinary cost remains paid; pricing COGS is an additional manufacturing/component/fulfillment reserve. Product gross profit is an analytical decomposition of the consolidated adjusted basis. A price residual does not turn the old manufacturing costs into new cash savings.

Other data-center HDD - all eighteen quarters

Quarter	Revenue	Ordinary COGS	Pricing COGS	Total COGS	Gross profit	Gross margin
Q3 2026	1,823	772	0	772	1,051	58%
Q4 2026	1,843	766	2	768	1,075	58%
Q1 2027	1,621	667	3	670	951	59%
Q2 2027	1,318	537	4	541	777	59%
Q3 2027	1,180	483	4	487	693	59%
Q4 2027	1,001	416	4	419	582	58%
Q1 2028	955	402	4	406	550	58%
Q2 2028	840	359	3	362	479	57%
Q3 2028	701	303	3	306	395	56%
Q4 2028	618	270	2	273	345	56%
Q1 2029	574	252	2	254	320	56%
Q2 2029	525	233	1	234	291	55%
Q3 2029	477	214	<1	214	263	55%
Q4 2029	425	192	0	192	233	55%
Q1 2030	372	168	0	168	204	55%
Q2 2030	348	157	0	157	190	55%
Q3 2030	324	146	0	146	177	55%
Q4 2030	296	134	0	134	162	55%

USD millions. Ordinary cost remains paid; pricing COGS is an additional manufacturing/component/fulfillment reserve. Product gross profit is an analytical decomposition of the consolidated adjusted basis. A price residual does not turn the old manufacturing costs into new cash savings.

Edge and IoT - all eighteen quarters

Quarter	Revenue	Ordinary COGS	Pricing COGS	Total COGS	Gross profit	Gross margin
Q3 2026	725	435	0	435	290	40%
Q4 2026	766	448	<1	449	316	41%
Q1 2027	752	440	<1	441	311	41%
Q2 2027	770	448	<1	448	322	42%
Q3 2027	780	452	0	452	328	42%
Q4 2027	805	467	0	467	338	42%
Q1 2028	785	455	0	455	330	42%
Q2 2028	800	464	0	464	336	42%
Q3 2028	815	473	0	473	342	42%
Q4 2028	840	487	0	487	353	42%
Q1 2029	810	466	0	466	344	43%
Q2 2029	825	474	0	474	351	43%
Q3 2029	840	483	0	483	357	43%
Q4 2029	865	497	0	497	368	43%
Q1 2030	830	473	0	473	357	43%
Q2 2030	845	482	0	482	363	43%
Q3 2030	860	490	0	490	370	43%
Q4 2030	885	504	0	504	381	43%

USD millions. Ordinary cost remains paid; pricing COGS is an additional manufacturing/component/fulfillment reserve. Product gross profit is an analytical decomposition of the consolidated adjusted basis. A price residual does not turn the old manufacturing costs into new cash savings.

Consolidated operating bridge

R&D and SG&A retain the inherited 56% / 44% central-cost allocation. Their combined ordinary quarterly cost rises from USD 300 million to USD 379 million. The pricing branches separately add their 3% operating-support cost. Additional commercial rent does not erase engineering, factory depreciation, support or administration.

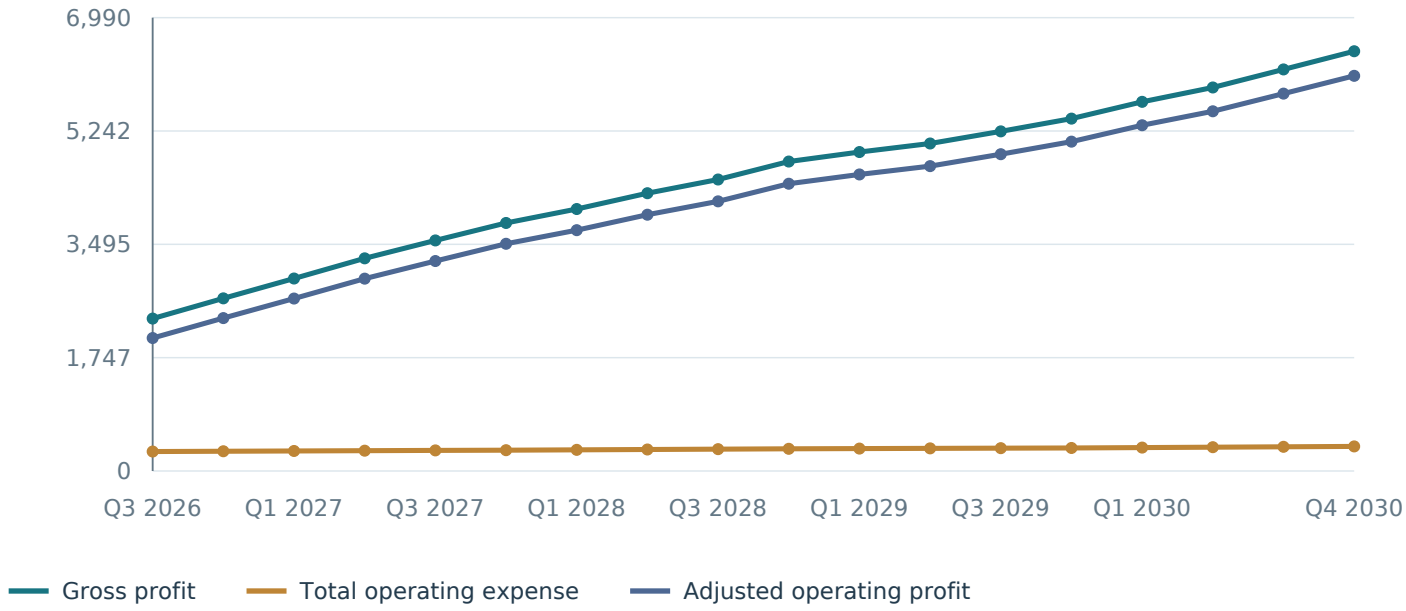
Quarter	Revenue	COGS	Gross profit	R&D	SG&A	Other opex	Operating profit	OP margin
Q3 2026	4,100	1,750	2,350	168	132	0	2,050	50%
Q4 2026	4,525	1,864	2,662	170	133	1	2,357	52%
Q1 2027	4,901	1,933	2,968	171	135	3	2,659	54%
Q2 2027	5,286	2,007	3,279	173	136	4	2,966	56%
Q3 2027	5,642	2,087	3,555	175	137	6	3,237	57%
Q4 2027	5,972	2,148	3,824	176	139	6	3,503	59%
Q1 2028	6,265	2,226	4,039	179	141	6	3,713	59%
Q2 2028	6,592	2,309	4,283	182	143	7	3,951	60%
Q3 2028	6,863	2,369	4,494	185	145	7	4,158	61%
Q4 2028	7,239	2,468	4,771	188	147	7	4,429	61%
Q1 2029	7,424	2,506	4,918	190	150	6	4,572	62%
Q2 2029	7,626	2,576	5,049	193	152	4	4,701	62%
Q3 2029	7,908	2,671	5,236	196	154	2	4,884	62%
Q4 2029	8,208	2,775	5,433	199	156	0	5,078	62%
Q1 2030	8,548	2,856	5,692	202	159	0	5,331	62%
Q2 2030	8,865	2,952	5,913	206	161	0	5,546	63%
Q3 2030	9,265	3,073	6,192	209	164	0	5,819	63%
Q4 2030	9,670	3,198	6,472	212	167	0	6,093	63%

All rows are model estimates on the sanctioned adjusted operating basis. Ordinary stock-compensation exclusions remain disclosed rather than relabeled as paid cash. The operating-cost path and high outer-year margins carry substantial uncertainty; the new price check validates neither a future yield curve nor an asset-life assumption.

Gross profit, operating expense and operating earnings

Model gross profit, operating expense and operating profit

USD millions; model estimates



Adjusted operating profit includes ordinary production depreciation and excludes stock compensation under the retained accounting convention. It is not EBITDA or free cash flow.

Quarter	Gross profit	Total operating expense	Adjusted operating profit
Q3 2026	2,350	300	2,050
Q4 2026	2,662	304	2,357
Q1 2027	2,968	309	2,659
Q2 2027	3,279	313	2,966
Q3 2027	3,555	318	3,237
Q4 2027	3,824	321	3,503
Q1 2028	4,039	326	3,713
Q2 2028	4,283	332	3,951
Q3 2028	4,494	337	4,158
Q4 2028	4,771	342	4,429
Q1 2029	4,918	346	4,572

Quarter	Gross profit	Total operating expense	Adjusted operating profit
Q2 2029	5,049	349	4,701
Q3 2029	5,236	352	4,884
Q4 2029	5,433	355	5,078
Q1 2030	5,692	361	5,331
Q2 2030	5,913	367	5,546
Q3 2030	6,192	373	5,819
Q4 2030	6,472	379	6,093

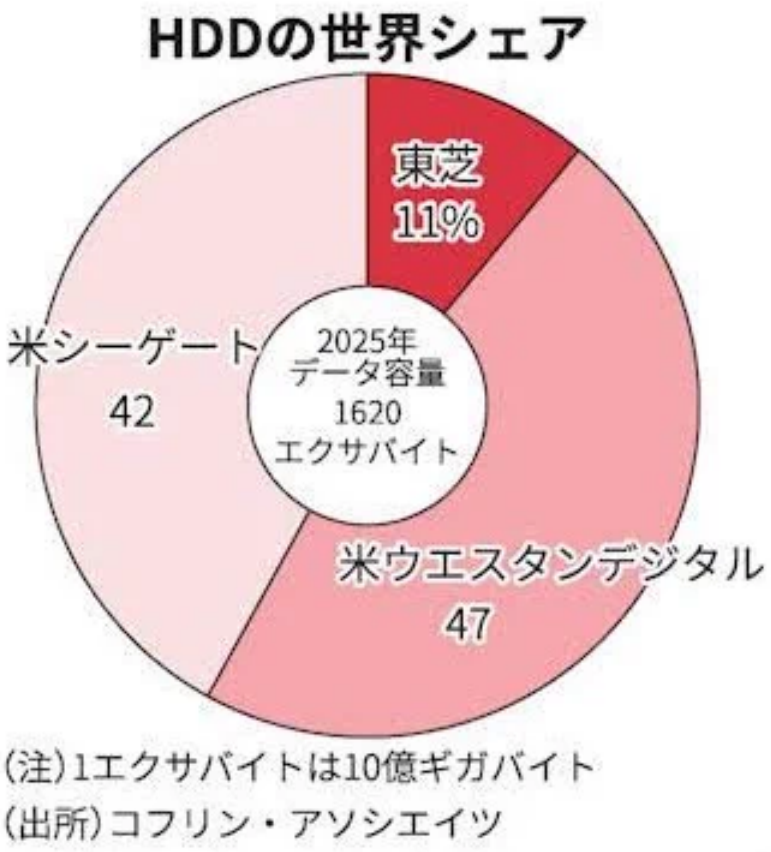
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Qualified competitor supply and the retained Toshiba concession

Toshiba's October 2 release says the expanded Laguna nearline line has made initial shipments. It targets nearly twice FY2025 annual production by FY2027 on a storage-capacity basis. This measures bytes, not finished-drive units; Toshiba FY2027 ends in March 2028. Exact accepted EB, utilization, contract prices and manufacturer realization remain unavailable. [TOS-1]

The retained competitor branch assigns 50% probability to a 4% conditional price concession on 50% of new or repriceable cloud/data-center sales. Phase is 25% in Q4 2027, 50% in Q1 2028, 75% in Q2 and full from Q3. From 2029, 50% overlap is removed because normalization already exists in reference pricing. Initial shipments establish a meaningful execution milestone, while protected contracts, qualification and demand absorption limit its pricing transmission.

The absolute signed Toshiba price/operating-profit concession is unchanged. It is not recalculated on the higher scarcity endpoint and does not remove ordinary factory costs. No additional unit loss is assigned. This avoids both a duplicated competitive penalty and an unsupported benefit from ignoring new competing supply.



Inherited Nikkei / Techno Systems Research exhibit, 2025 storage-capacity basis: Toshiba 11%, WDC 47%, Seagate 42%; total 1,620 EB. Original pixels and source decimals remain unchanged. Capacity share is distinct from revenue, drive-unit share and incremental factory output.

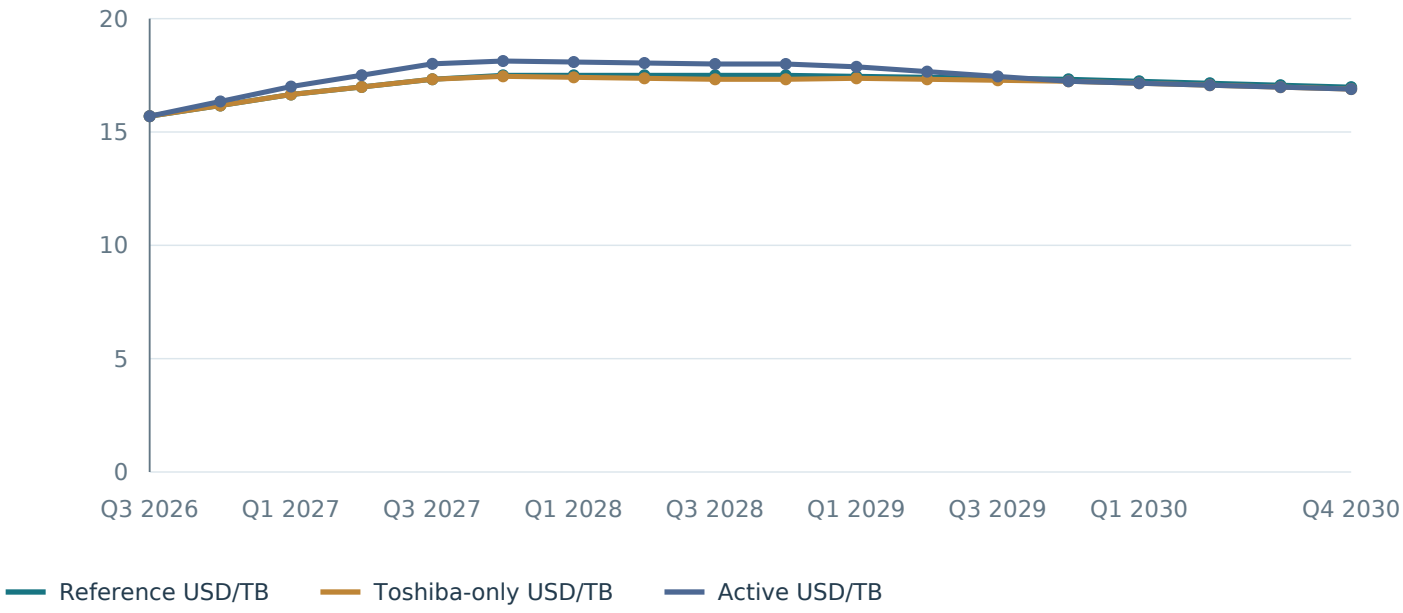
Quarter	Toshiba phase	Overlap	Weighted concession	Loss US cents/TB	Absolute OP concession
Q3 2026	0%	0%	0%	0	0
Q4 2026	0%	0%	0%	0	0
Q1 2027	0%	0%	0%	0	0
Q2 2027	0%	0%	0%	0	0
Q3 2027	0%	0%	0%	0	0
Q4 2027	25%	0%	<1%	4	-12
Q1 2028	50%	0%	<1%	9	-27
Q2 2028	75%	0%	<1%	13	-42
Q3 2028	100%	0%	1%	17	-59
Q4 2028	100%	0%	1%	17	-62
Q1 2029	100%	50%	<1%	9	-32
Q2 2029	100%	50%	<1%	9	-34

Quarter	Toshiba phase	Overlap	Weighted concession	Loss US cents/TB	Absolute OP concession
Q3 2029	100%	50%	<1%	9	-35
Q4 2029	100%	50%	<1%	9	-37
Q1 2030	100%	50%	<1%	9	-39
Q2 2030	100%	50%	<1%	9	-40
Q3 2030	100%	50%	<1%	9	-42
Q4 2030	100%	50%	<1%	8	-44

Reference and selected blended pricing

Reference, competitor-adjusted and active pricing

USD per TB; analytical blended effective price



Active price retains the absolute competitor concession and adds the current weighted scarcity premium once. Chart observations retain technical precision; whole-number companion values are for reading.

Quarter	Reference USD/TB	Toshiba-only USD/TB	Active USD/TB
Q3 2026	16	16	16
Q4 2026	16	16	16
Q1 2027	17	17	17

Quarter	Reference USD/TB	Toshiba-only USD/TB	Active USD/TB
Q2 2027	17	17	18
Q3 2027	17	17	18
Q4 2027	17	17	18
Q1 2028	17	17	18
Q2 2028	17	17	18
Q3 2028	17	17	18
Q4 2028	17	17	18
Q1 2029	17	17	18
Q2 2029	17	17	18
Q3 2029	17	17	17
Q4 2029	17	17	17
Q1 2030	17	17	17
Q2 2030	17	17	17
Q3 2030	17	17	17
Q4 2030	17	17	17

The reference already rises through 2027, is broadly flat in 2028 and eases later. The scarcity phase fades through 2029. Stronger shipment and mix assumptions remain even after that premium expires; no permanent USD 40-70 company-wide selling price is assumed.

Calendar and fiscal-year reconciliation

Calendar year	Quarters shown	Revenue	Gross profit	Opex	Operating profit
2026	2	8,625	5,012	604	4,407
2027	4	21,801	13,625	1,260	12,365
2028	4	26,959	17,588	1,337	16,251
2029	4	31,166	20,637	1,402	19,235
2030	4	36,348	24,268	1,480	22,788

Calendar 2026 contains only the two forecast quarters; it is not a full-year actual-plus-forecast total. All other displayed calendar years contain four modeled quarters.

Fiscal year ending around June	Mapped calendar window	Revenue	Operating profit
FY2027	Q3 2026 - Q2 2027	18,812	10,032
FY2028	Q3 2027 - Q2 2028	24,472	14,405
FY2029	Q3 2028 - Q2 2029	29,151	17,859
FY2030	Q3 2029 - Q2 2030	33,530	20,839

The fiscal-year guide comparison uses the repeated nearest-quarter mapping. July management expected FY2027 revenue growth to exceed FY2026 growth of 34%, without an exact full-year revenue guide. The outer-year totals are analytical extensions rather than subsequently reported results.

Cash, debt, awards and completed financing events

Dated reported anchor	USD million	Scope
July 3 cash	1,704	Reported quarter-end unrestricted cash anchor
July 3 debt carrying value	3,565	Current 185 plus long-term 3,380; differs from nominal principal
Quarter CFO / capex / free cash flow	1,305 / 187 / 1,118	FCF is CFO less specified property/leasehold acquisitions
FY2026 CFO / capex / free cash flow	3,674 / 569 / 3,105	Reported year; not a forward funding schedule
FY2026 stock compensation	213	Adjusted earnings exclusions remain economic costs
FY2026 award net-settlement taxes	119	Financing cash, distinct from ordinary operating cost

On July 28 management said USD 1,000 million high-yield senior notes had already been extinguished during July. This is completed financing after the July 3 balance sheet. The separate September 8 exchangeable-note redemption settled about USD 151 million remaining principal with about USD 151 million cash and 1,647,862 ordinary shares. It was announced September 9 and is also completed. Neither event is described as a future remaining liability. [Q4-CALL; STX-NOTE]

A simple subtraction from July 3 cash and debt would omit intervening operations, buybacks, other financing and carrying-value adjustments. It cannot be labeled a newly reported September balance sheet. Management's expectation for about USD 2,400 million debt at the next quarter end was guidance, not an observed balance. Revolver-inclusive liquidity also differs from cash.

FY2027 capital spending was targeted at 4-6% of sales. Added heads/media content and longer process cycles require investment even without more finished-drive units. The engine does not contain a complete quarterly cash, debt-principal, working-capital, dividend, buyback or asset-activation roll-forward. Reported cash

generation and the capital-intensity discussion support context, but do not establish that every future capital need is funded. No invented cash balance or D&A cohort is added here.

Share conventions, note settlement and valuation basis

The latest supplement shows approximately 227 million end-quarter ordinary shares, 232 million GAAP weighted diluted shares and 231 million adjusted weighted diluted shares. Period-weighted EPS counts differ from a point-in-time basic count. The first-quarter guide uses about 231 million adjusted diluted shares, including about 2 million estimated note-related dilution. [STX-REL; STX-SUP; Q4-CALL]

The source release footnote describes gross if-converted shares of about 2 million for the quarter and 6 million for the year, while its non-GAAP reconciliation table and supplemental footnote show adjustments of minus 1 million and minus 2 million. These are distinct source presentations; this report does not invent an independent gross-to-net reconciliation.

The model retains 231 million diluted ordinary shares in all eighteen quarters. It does not add both the old if-converted estimate and the later delivered shares again, substitute the lower historical basic count, or assume stock-price-dependent repurchases erase future awards. Subsequent actual diluted shares, capped-call effects, award settlement and cash usage remain required monitoring items.

The method values adjusted operating earnings at 20x without a separate enterprise-value, debt subtraction, net-income or EBITDA conversion. Financing affects risk and cash, while the sanctioned method remains explicit. The broker's fiscal earnings multiple and target are not alternative calculation inputs.

Seven-category analytical reassessment

Category	Points	Current assessment
Core Thesis	18	Qualified heads, media and HAMR execution are difficult to reproduce. WDC and Toshiba remain viable, preventing permanent monopoly credit.
Cycle Stage	9	Commercial ramp, build-to-order allocations and contract visibility support the cycle; qualification and customer deployments still condition sales.
TAM Expansion	8	Growing retained data expands persistent storage, bounded by accepted capacity and substitution. The new checks overlap the existing opportunity.
Catalysts	5	Total HAMR crossover, Mozaic 4 share within HAMR, FY2027 scaling and later Mozaic 5 qualification have different denominators and timing.
Macro	9	Cloud/AI activity and retention remain strong; funding, power, construction and input costs can delay conversion.
Alpha	2	Widely followed evidence offers little discovery premium. The edge comes from qualified-capacity, price-realization and paid-cost decomposition.
Risks	-4	One deduction each for demand/customer timing, technology/manufacturing, competition/substitution and financial/policy exposure.
Total	47 / 60 = 78 / 100	High Conviction under the existing scale; separately protected Excel Base 78

All seven categories were reassessed. A stronger conditional price endpoint improves the earnings bridge without establishing exclusive alpha, a completed catalyst, funded capacity or an additional durable moat. Analytical Base remains 78 and the separate protected portfolio Excel Base remains 78. Neither is a second probability applied to earnings or the ceiling.

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Fifteen complete forward-four-quarter valuations

Each valuation quarter uses its own adjusted operating profit plus the following three quarters, multiplied by 20 and divided by 231 million diluted shares. The last three modeled operating quarters support earlier complete windows; they are not assigned incomplete standalone ceilings. Farther windows carry increasing uncertainty.

All fifteen valuation-quarter ceilings

USD per share; 20x forward-four-quarter adjusted OP / 231 million shares



Q4 2027 uses Q4 2027 through Q3 2028. Every ceiling is linked to four explicit operating-profit terms below; probability has already entered the selected operating branches.

Quarter	USD per share
Q3 2026	869
Q4 2026	971
Q1 2027	1,071
Q2 2027	1,162
Q3 2027	1,247
Q4 2027	1,327
Q1 2028	1,407
Q2 2028	1,481
Q3 2028	1,546
Q4 2028	1,609
Q1 2029	1,665
Q2 2029	1,731
Q3 2029	1,804
Q4 2029	1,885
Q1 2030	1,973

Valuation quarter	Earnings window	Four-quarter OP	Multiple	Shares M	Ceiling USD
Q3 2026	Q3 2026 - Q2 2027	10,032	20x	231	869
Q4 2026	Q4 2026 - Q3 2027	11,219	20x	231	971
Q1 2027	Q1 2027 - Q4 2027	12,365	20x	231	1,071
Q2 2027	Q2 2027 - Q1 2028	13,419	20x	231	1,162
Q3 2027	Q3 2027 - Q2 2028	14,405	20x	231	1,247
Q4 2027	Q4 2027 - Q3 2028	15,325	20x	231	1,327
Q1 2028	Q1 2028 - Q4 2028	16,251	20x	231	1,407
Q2 2028	Q2 2028 - Q1 2029	17,110	20x	231	1,481
Q3 2028	Q3 2028 - Q2 2029	17,859	20x	231	1,546
Q4 2028	Q4 2028 - Q3 2029	18,586	20x	231	1,609
Q1 2029	Q1 2029 - Q4 2029	19,235	20x	231	1,665
Q2 2029	Q2 2029 - Q1 2030	19,994	20x	231	1,731
Q3 2029	Q3 2029 - Q2 2030	20,839	20x	231	1,804
Q4 2029	Q4 2029 - Q3 2030	21,774	20x	231	1,885
Q1 2030	Q1 2030 - Q4 2030	22,788	20x	231	1,973

Explicit operating-profit chains 1-3

Q3 2026 valuation: all four earnings terms

Term	Operating quarter	Adjusted OP
1	Q3 2026	2,050
2	Q4 2026	2,357
3	Q1 2027	2,659
4	Q2 2027	2,966
Sum	Forward four quarters	10,032
Valuation	Sum x 20 / 231 million shares	USD 869 per share

Q4 2026 valuation: all four earnings terms

Term	Operating quarter	Adjusted OP
1	Q4 2026	2,357
2	Q1 2027	2,659
3	Q2 2027	2,966
4	Q3 2027	3,237
Sum	Forward four quarters	11,219
Valuation	Sum x 20 / 231 million shares	USD 971 per share

Q1 2027 valuation: all four earnings terms

Term	Operating quarter	Adjusted OP
1	Q1 2027	2,659
2	Q2 2027	2,966
3	Q3 2027	3,237
4	Q4 2027	3,503
Sum	Forward four quarters	12,365
Valuation	Sum x 20 / 231 million shares	USD 1,071 per share

Explicit operating-profit chains 4-6

Q2 2027 valuation: all four earnings terms

Term	Operating quarter	Adjusted OP
1	Q2 2027	2,966
2	Q3 2027	3,237
3	Q4 2027	3,503
4	Q1 2028	3,713
Sum	Forward four quarters	13,419
Valuation	Sum x 20 / 231 million shares	USD 1,162 per share

Q3 2027 valuation: all four earnings terms

Term	Operating quarter	Adjusted OP
1	Q3 2027	3,237
2	Q4 2027	3,503
3	Q1 2028	3,713
4	Q2 2028	3,951
Sum	Forward four quarters	14,405
Valuation	Sum x 20 / 231 million shares	USD 1,247 per share

Q4 2027 valuation: all four earnings terms

Term	Operating quarter	Adjusted OP
1	Q4 2027	3,503
2	Q1 2028	3,713
3	Q2 2028	3,951
4	Q3 2028	4,158
Sum	Forward four quarters	15,325
Valuation	Sum x 20 / 231 million shares	USD 1,327 per share

Explicit operating-profit chains 7-9

Q1 2028 valuation: all four earnings terms

Term	Operating quarter	Adjusted OP
1	Q1 2028	3,713
2	Q2 2028	3,951
3	Q3 2028	4,158
4	Q4 2028	4,429
Sum	Forward four quarters	16,251
Valuation	Sum x 20 / 231 million shares	USD 1,407 per share

Q2 2028 valuation: all four earnings terms

Term	Operating quarter	Adjusted OP
1	Q2 2028	3,951
2	Q3 2028	4,158
3	Q4 2028	4,429
4	Q1 2029	4,572
Sum	Forward four quarters	17,110
Valuation	Sum x 20 / 231 million shares	USD 1,481 per share

Q3 2028 valuation: all four earnings terms

Term	Operating quarter	Adjusted OP
1	Q3 2028	4,158
2	Q4 2028	4,429
3	Q1 2029	4,572
4	Q2 2029	4,701
Sum	Forward four quarters	17,859
Valuation	Sum x 20 / 231 million shares	USD 1,546 per share

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Explicit operating-profit chains 10-12

Q4 2028 valuation: all four earnings terms

Term	Operating quarter	Adjusted OP
1	Q4 2028	4,429
2	Q1 2029	4,572
3	Q2 2029	4,701
4	Q3 2029	4,884
Sum	Forward four quarters	18,586
Valuation	Sum x 20 / 231 million shares	USD 1,609 per share

Q1 2029 valuation: all four earnings terms

Term	Operating quarter	Adjusted OP
1	Q1 2029	4,572
2	Q2 2029	4,701
3	Q3 2029	4,884
4	Q4 2029	5,078
Sum	Forward four quarters	19,235
Valuation	Sum x 20 / 231 million shares	USD 1,665 per share

Q2 2029 valuation: all four earnings terms

Term	Operating quarter	Adjusted OP
1	Q2 2029	4,701
2	Q3 2029	4,884
3	Q4 2029	5,078
4	Q1 2030	5,331
Sum	Forward four quarters	19,994
Valuation	Sum x 20 / 231 million shares	USD 1,731 per share

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Explicit operating-profit chains 13-15

Q3 2029 valuation: all four earnings terms

Term	Operating quarter	Adjusted OP
1	Q3 2029	4,884
2	Q4 2029	5,078
3	Q1 2030	5,331
4	Q2 2030	5,546
Sum	Forward four quarters	20,839
Valuation	Sum x 20 / 231 million shares	USD 1,804 per share

Q4 2029 valuation: all four earnings terms

Term	Operating quarter	Adjusted OP
1	Q4 2029	5,078
2	Q1 2030	5,331
3	Q2 2030	5,546
4	Q3 2030	5,819
Sum	Forward four quarters	21,774
Valuation	Sum x 20 / 231 million shares	USD 1,885 per share

Q1 2030 valuation: all four earnings terms

Term	Operating quarter	Adjusted OP
1	Q1 2030	5,331
2	Q2 2030	5,546
3	Q3 2030	5,819
4	Q4 2030	6,093
Sum	Forward four quarters	22,788
Valuation	Sum x 20 / 231 million shares	USD 1,973 per share

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The fresh revision versus the total current branch

The new endpoint replaces the earlier endpoint within one existing branch. In the active Q4 2027 through Q3 2028 window, fresh nearline revenue is USD 374 million. Incremental cost of sales consumes USD 37 million and operating support USD 11 million, leaving USD 325 million additional adjusted operating profit. Edge contributes zero in this window because its episode has already expired.

Quarter	Old total scarcity R	Current total scarcity R	Fresh nearline R	Fresh Edge R	Fresh COGS	Fresh opex	Fresh OP
Q3 2026	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
Q4 2026	24	41	17	6	3	<1	20
Q1 2027	49	85	37	7	5	1	37
Q2 2027	76	134	58	5	7	2	55

Quarter	Old total scarcity R	Current total scarcity R	Fresh nearline R	Fresh Edge R	Fresh COGS	Fresh opex	Fresh OP
Q3 2027	103	184	81	0	8	2	70
Q4 2027	107	192	86	0	9	3	74
Q1 2028	114	205	91	0	9	3	79
Q2 2028	120	217	96	0	10	3	84
Q3 2028	126	227	101	0	10	3	88
Q4 2028	133	240	107	0	11	3	93
Q1 2029	104	188	83	0	8	2	72
Q2 2029	73	130	58	0	6	2	50
Q3 2029	38	69	30	0	3	<1	26
Q4 2029	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
Q1 2030	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
Q2 2030	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
Q3 2030	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
Q4 2030	0	0	0	0	0	0	0

Same-quarter active comparison	Previous	Updated
Forward-four-quarter OP; USD million	15,000	15,325
Q4 2027 ceiling; USD per share	1,299	1,327
Change	-	+2%

Only this dedicated revision bridge and precision supplement compare the earlier saved model. The current product and consolidated forecast tables already contain the revised branch once. The gross contribution of the entire current scarcity branch must not be described as newly created earnings.

Seven bounded diagnostic cases

Diagnostic	Q4 2026 ceiling	Q4 2027 ceiling	Q4 2026 new Edge R	Q4 2026 new Edge OP
Earlier USD 30 endpoint; Edge off	956	1,299	0	0
Selected USD 40; Edge off	970	1,327	0	0
Nearline probability zero	938	1,264	6	5
Upper USD 70 transaction endpoint	1,015	1,411	6	5
Edge effective quantity 10% lower	970	1,327	0	0
Edge effective quantity 10% higher	973	1,327	12	10
Fresh endpoint increment delayed two quarters	961	1,325	6	5

The old-endpoint control recovers the earlier price branch and turns off the new Edge episode. The nearline-probability-zero case removes the entire selected scarcity branch, not only the newest endpoint change. The upper USD 70 observation is a conditional stress and receives no additional weight in the active case.

The two-quarter delay applies only to the fresh USD 40-minus-30 endpoint increment. It preserves the old price branch and original ordinary costs. This tests transmission timing rather than delaying all shipments or replacing the whole accepted-capacity path.

Edge quantity alternatives alter the same three-quarter price residual after full baseline subtraction. They leave the active Q4 2027 ceiling unchanged because their revenue has expired. A larger diluted share count or lower selected multiple would mechanically reduce the ceiling; neither bank sentiment nor a current share price changes the existing denominator or 20x method.

Risks, failure channels and cross-company overlap

Risk class	Points	Failure channel
Demand and customer timing	-1	Cloud deployments, construction, power or inventory delays reduce accepted EB and renewal pricing.
Technology and manufacturing	-1	HAMR yields, longer cycles, warranty experience or qualification misses raise cost and limit deliveries.
Competition and substitution	-1	WDC/Toshiba accepted density and supply or cheaper SSDs close scarcity and constrain price.
Financial and policy	-1	Debt service, capital needs, award settlement, input inflation or restrictions reduce shareholder cash.

STX and WDC share a storage cycle, but a company-specific market-share gain cannot be added to every supplier. Toshiba capacity targets measure bytes and require accepted production before their competitive effect is fully realized. Scarcity can coexist with those risks during a constrained ramp.

SNDK, Kioxia, Samsung, SK hynix and Micron serve adjacent memory/storage tiers. Their price increases are not directly applied as a NAND multiplier to HDD sales. Expensive NAND can improve HDD relative economics while memory components also cost money. Optical, networking, compute and storage depend on overlapping customer funding and power deployment; their spending wallets cannot all be counted as incremental Seagate revenue.

Dated checkpoints and what would change the thesis

Checkpoint	Evidence that matters	Failure or counter
October 27, 2026 result	Accepted EB, net USD/TB, guide and approximately 50% adjusted OP margin	A dealer quote without manufacturer capture reduces transmission; no unreported beat assumed.
Calendar year-end 2026	Total HAMR crossover; Mozaic 4 share inside HAMR	Different denominators; a missed qualification or mix milestone reduces the relevant path.
FY2027 / around June 2027	Growth above prior 34%, manufacturing expense, accepted density and renewals	Higher sales with unfavorable input/warranty cost can miss profit despite scarcity.
Late 2027 onward	Mozaic 5 qualification followed by accepted commercial shipments	Samples and qualification are not full-volume revenue.
Each filing	Cash, capex, debt, actual awards/shares and contract economics	Capex beyond 4-6% or unexpected dilution requires a fresh cost/funding/denominator bridge.
2028-30	Accepted industry supply, substitution, renewal pricing and retained-data economics	LOW outer-year mix/margins and fading premiums require repeated source validation.

The most useful next observation is realized manufacturer pricing on accepted capacity. It can validate or contradict the limited branch without requiring every trade to become a fleet-wide price. Ordinary execution, costs and cash must improve alongside revenue for the investment thesis to generate excess returns.

Primary-call coverage and remaining source gaps

The newest completed earnings calls, April 28 and July 28, were read in full through prepared remarks, all question-and-answer turns, closing and operator conclusion. Both are issuer-hosted corrected transcripts: nineteen pages each, with sixteen April Q&A turns and fourteen July turns. Transcript phonetic or indiscernible qualifiers remain in the originals. No official audio comparison is claimed. [Q3-CALL; Q4-CALL]

The July file URL contains July 27 text, while the cover, page headers and official event feed identify July 28. The document/event date controls the call label. The release PDF separately carries a July 29 Singapore dateline. These differences are retained without inventing a timezone or publication explanation.

The September 10 Goldman conference has an official webcast but only the previously saved secondary transcript. The September 9 Citi event has no transcript/presentation attachment in the issuer feed and was not listened to in this review. Neither is represented as a newly completed primary-audio review. The October 14 results-scheduling download loops redirects, while the preserved issuer event feed independently confirms October 27 at 2 pm PT / 5 pm ET.

The owner report has twenty-eight original pages. Relevant pricing pages were visually reviewed and narrative pages 1-14 were read; original pages 2-3 are embedded privately here. Dense bank forecast matrices were not reconstructed or imported. Producer net realization, contract-renewal mix, Edge units/ASP and exact product costs remain undisclosed. The selected finite probabilities and LOW cost/quantity proxies make those limits explicit rather than require official confirmation before considering useful evidence.

The retained model lacks a fully specified forward asset-life, factory-cohort, debt/cash and award/repurchase schedule. Near-term consolidated guidance has HIGH source confidence; product allocations and outer-year earnings are LOW confidence. The local full-master native-open limitation is a separate workbook verification issue and does not constitute a reported issuer financial fact.

Source register and original exhibit provenance

HDD-P2 | Morgan Stanley Research, Erik W. Woodring and listed team. October 20, 2026 at 03:44 UTC. Owner-supplied twenty-eight-page earnings preview. Original SHA-256 f1becebecbd71067332d91e407d2a382b1973e5f0d8c413dde427f30d770902b. Pages 2-3 support attributed price checks and the hypothetical floating-share example. Licensed originals remain private.

STX-REL | July 29, 2026 PDF dateline; July 28 event. FY2026 Q4 financial release.

STX-SUP | July 28, 2026. FY2026 Q4 supplemental information.

STX-10K | August 2026. FY2026 Form 10-K.

Q4-CALL | July 28, 2026. Issuer-hosted corrected Q4 management transcript.

Q3-CALL | April 28, 2026. Issuer-hosted corrected Q3 management transcript.

STX-Q3 | April 28, 2026. FY2026 Q3 financial release.

STX-NOTE | September 9, 2026 announcement; September 8 settlement. Completed exchangeable-note redemption.

STX-EVENT | October 14, 2026 scheduling notice. October 27 FQ1 FY2027 earnings event.

TOS-1 | October 2, 2026. Toshiba expanded nearline line initial shipments.

D1 | July 30, 2026. Amazon Q2 management spending outlook.

D2 | July 29, 2026. Microsoft FY2026 Q4 management call.

D3 | July 22, 2026. Alphabet Q2 management spending outlook.

D4 | July 29, 2026. Meta Q2 results.

STX-QUOTE | September 21, 2026 close. Historical dated market snapshot.

STX-GS | September 10, 2026. Goldman Sachs management conference; secondary transcript retained.

Earlier scarcity source: the preserved broker crop itself is undated; an exact-match secondary synopsis suggests October 5. It is the same commercial mechanism and source group as the newer observation, not independent confirmation. Its superseded USD 30 endpoint is retained only in the explicit revision/diagnostic comparisons.

The two supplemental pages and Toshiba share exhibit retain original pixels/numbers. The share exhibit uses 2025 storage-capacity share and supplies no new drive-unit, revenue or factory-output quantity. The local manifest binds every source original and rendered exhibit.

Technical precision supplement - exact controls and dated anchors

This appendix preserves technical precision for reconciliation only. Main financial copy uses whole amounts. Exact premiums, small costs and four-term arithmetic below are not additional forecasts.

Control / dated observation	Exact value
Historical September 21 close; USD/share	877.330000
Historical basic shares; million	226.645000
Effective anchor coefficient	0.016011
Q4 2027 previous ceiling	1,298.738302
Q4 2027 current ceiling	1,326.872069
Same-quarter change; percent	2.166238
Current active F4 OP; USD M	15,325.372393
Fresh active F4 OP; USD M	324.945000
July EPS guide midpoint / range; USD	7.300000 / 0.200000
Known guide SBC excluded; USD/share	0.260000
September note principal; approximate USD M	150.700000
September cash settlement; USD M	150.970000
September delivered ordinary shares	1,647,862

Exact physical and price reconciliation

Quarter	Capacity EB	Demand EB	Shipped EB	HAMR mix	Conversion
Q3 2026	215.000000	224.250000	215.000000	0.450000	1.000000
Q4 2026	230.000000	234.000000	230.000000	0.500000	1.000000
Q1 2027	244.000000	304.687500	244.000000	0.600000	1.000000
Q2 2027	258.000000	304.687500	258.000000	0.700000	1.000000
Q3 2027	270.000000	304.687500	270.000000	0.750000	1.000000
Q4 2027	285.000000	304.687500	285.000000	0.800000	1.000000
Q1 2028	303.000000	365.625000	303.000000	0.820000	1.000000
Q2 2028	321.000000	365.625000	321.000000	0.850000	1.000000
Q3 2028	336.000000	365.625000	336.000000	0.880000	1.000000
Q4 2028	355.500000	365.625000	355.500000	0.900000	1.000000
Q1 2029	370.000000	433.485000	370.000000	0.910000	1.000000
Q2 2029	385.000000	433.485000	385.000000	0.920000	1.000000
Q3 2029	405.000000	433.485000	405.000000	0.930000	1.000000
Q4 2029	426.000000	433.485000	426.000000	0.940000	1.000000
Q1 2030	450.000000	531.852750	450.000000	0.950000	1.000000
Q2 2030	470.000000	531.852750	470.000000	0.955000	1.000000
Q3 2030	495.000000	531.852750	495.000000	0.960000	1.000000
Q4 2030	520.000000	531.852750	520.000000	0.965000	1.000000

Quarter	Reference USD/TB	Toshiba-only USD/TB	Phase	Weighted premium USD/TB	Active USD/TB
Q3 2026	15.697674	15.697674	0.000000	0.000000	15.697674
Q4 2026	16.168605	16.168605	0.250000	0.178735	16.347340
Q1 2027	16.653663	16.653663	0.500000	0.350195	17.003858
Q2 2027	16.986736	16.986736	0.750000	0.517798	17.504534
Q3 2027	17.326471	17.326471	1.000000	0.680206	18.006677
Q4 2027	17.499735	17.455986	1.000000	0.675008	18.130994
Q1 2028	17.499735	17.412237	1.000000	0.675008	18.087245
Q2 2028	17.499735	17.368487	1.000000	0.675008	18.043495

Quarter	Reference USD/TB	Toshiba-only USD/TB	Phase	Weighted premium USD/TB	Active USD/TB
Q3 2028	17.499735	17.324738	1.000000	0.675008	17.999746
Q4 2028	17.499735	17.324738	1.000000	0.675008	17.999746
Q1 2029	17.455821	17.368542	0.750000	0.507244	17.875786
Q2 2029	17.412017	17.324957	0.500000	0.338820	17.663777
Q3 2029	17.368323	17.281481	0.250000	0.169738	17.451219
Q4 2029	17.324738	17.238114	0.000000	0.000000	17.238114
Q1 2030	17.237457	17.151270	0.000000	0.000000	17.151270
Q2 2030	17.150616	17.064863	0.000000	0.000000	17.064863
Q3 2030	17.064212	16.978891	0.000000	0.000000	16.978891
Q4 2030	16.978243	16.893352	0.000000	0.000000	16.893352

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Exact finite Edge residual

Quarter	Conditional R	Entire baseline R	Positive residual	Weighted new R
Q4 2026	833.750000	760.000000	73.750000	5.531250
Q1 2027	833.750000	745.000000	88.750000	6.656250
Q2 2027	833.750000	765.000000	68.750000	5.156250

Quarter	New R	New COGS	New opex	New OP
Q4 2026	5.531250	0.829687	0.165937	4.535625
Q1 2027	6.656250	0.998437	0.199687	5.458125
Q2 2027	5.156250	0.773437	0.154687	4.228125

Exact four-term valuation reconciliation 1-5

Valuation quarter	Four adjusted OP terms; USD M	F4 OP	Multiple / shares M	Ceiling USD
Q3 2026	2,050.000000 + 2,357.460304 + 2,658.931124 + 2,965.666815	10,032.058243	20 / 231	868.576471
Q4 2026	2,357.460304 + 2,658.931124 + 2,965.666815 + 3,237.295771	11,219.354014	20 / 231	971.372642
Q1 2027	2,658.931124 + 2,965.666815 + 3,237.295771 + 3,503.336018	12,365.229728	20 / 231	1,070.582660
Q2 2027	2,965.666815 + 3,237.295771 + 3,503.336018 + 3,713.037493	13,419.336097	20 / 231	1,161.847281
Q3 2027	3,237.295771 + 3,503.336018 + 3,713.037493 + 3,951.470099	14,405.139381	20 / 231	1,247.198215

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Exact four-term valuation reconciliation 6-10

Valuation quarter	Four adjusted OP terms; USD M	F4 OP	Multiple / shares M	Ceiling USD
Q4 2027	3,503.336018 + 3,713.037493 + 3,951.470099 + 4,157.528783	15,325.372393	20 / 231	1,326.872069
Q1 2028	3,713.037493 + 3,951.470099 + 4,157.528783 + 4,429.092791	16,251.129165	20 / 231	1,407.024170
Q2 2028	3,951.470099 + 4,157.528783 + 4,429.092791 + 4,572.166739	17,110.258411	20 / 231	1,481.407655
Q3 2028	4,157.528783 + 4,429.092791 + 4,572.166739 + 4,700.544839	17,859.333151	20 / 231	1,546.262611
Q4 2028	4,429.092791 + 4,572.166739 + 4,700.544839 + 4,884.345883	18,586.150252	20 / 231	1,609.190498

Exact four-term valuation reconciliation 11-15

Valuation quarter	Four adjusted OP terms; USD M	F4 OP	Multiple / shares M	Ceiling USD
Q1 2029	4,572.166739 + 4,700.544839 + 4,884.345883 + 5,077.944173	19,235.001634	20 / 231	1,665.368107
Q2 2029	4,700.544839 + 4,884.345883 + 5,077.944173 + 5,330.868053	19,993.702948	20 / 231	1,731.056532
Q3 2029	4,884.345883 + 5,077.944173 + 5,330.868053 + 5,546.190298	20,839.348406	20 / 231	1,804.272589
Q4 2029	5,077.944173 + 5,330.868053 + 5,546.190298 + 5,818.508959	21,773.511482	20 / 231	1,885.152509
Q1 2030	5,330.868053 + 5,546.190298 + 5,818.508959 + 6,092.859185	22,788.426494	20 / 231	1,973.023939